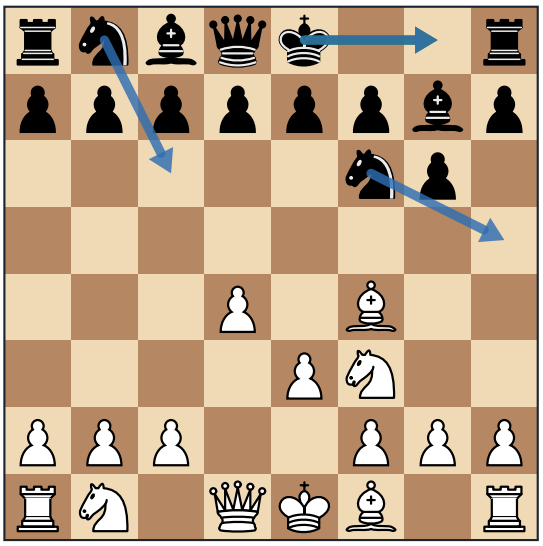
London System

ECO A48-D02 | 4 named lines | d4 systems (London, Colle, Torre, Trompowsky)

In one sentence: Low-theory 1.d4 systems: a solid setup that you can reach against many Black replies.

Memory pattern: c3, d4, e3, Bf4 or Bg5, then Ne5 and a kingside plan.



Main line: 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Bf4 Bg7 4.e3

Key ideas

1. Build a pyramid with c3, d4, e3, develop bishops outside the chain.
2. London: Bf4, e3, Nbd2, Bd3, Ne5.
3. Colle/Torre: Nbd2 with a quick e4 break.
4. Trompowsky: Bg5 at move 2, with a flexible, offbeat character.
5. Plans involve Ne5, f4 or e4 break, and kingside attacks.

Reading the diagram

Blue arrows = thematic plan moves for the side to move. Green arrow = engine's best move.
Engine at the end of the main line: **+0.07** (equal, depth 15). Best: O-O.

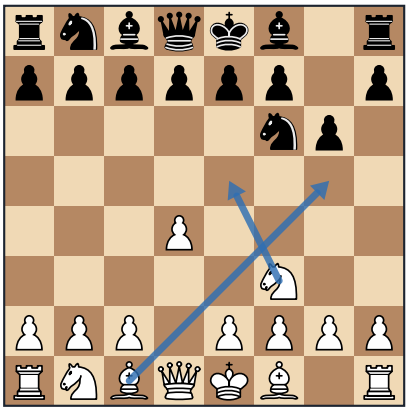
The five coach questions

1. Ideal pawn structure?	A compact pyramid (c3/d4/e3), fast development and flexible plans.
2. Where does my king go?	Castle short; the king shelters behind e3/f2.
3. Best minor pieces?	Bf4/Bg5, Bd3, Nbd2-f3-e5, Qc2/Qb3.
4. Main middlegame plan?	Complete the setup, castle, then Ne5/Qf3 or e4; against ...c5/...Qb6 trade or defend b2.
5. What does my opponent want?	White wants a safe fast setup and a kingside plan; Black wants ...c5/...Bf5 and an equal fight for the centre.

The main line, move by move

Most common continuation in the database: 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Bf4 Bg7 4.e3

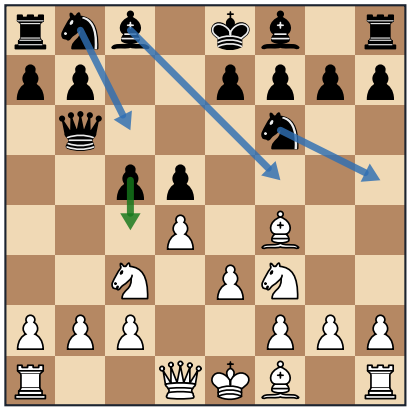
Move	Why it is played
1. d4	Center. Occupies the center with a pawn.
1... Nf6	Develops the knight to f6.
2. Nf3	Develops the knight to f3.
2... g6	Gains space on the wing.
3. Bf4	London bishop. Develops the bishop to f4.
3... Bg7	Fianchetto: the bishop takes the long diagonal.
4. e3	Pawn move that supports the center or prepares a break.



After 1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6

Key variations

The most important named branches (ranked by how much theory lies beneath them). Diagram arrows: blue = plan moves, green = Stockfish.



Position after the line

Poisoned Pawn Variation D02 | 1 lines

`1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 d5 3.Bf4 c5 4.e3 Qb6 5.Nc3`

Stockfish: **+0.26** (slightly better for White, depth 14). Best next move: c4.
What to look for: d5 (take the center); Nf6 (develop); e6 (solid)

Detailed repertoire notes

London System (D00-D02, White)

`1.d4 d5 2.Bf4 Nf6 3.e3 c5 4.c3 Nc6 5.Nd2 e6 6.Ngf3 Bd6 7.Bg3 O-O 8.Bd3 b6 9.Ne5 Bb7`

Idea: Develop the dark bishop first, build c3-d4-e3, and reach familiar positions fast.

Structure: Pyramid c3-d4-e3 with a solid center; the plan is Ne5 + Bd3, or e4, or kingside attack.

Pieces: Bf4 (or g3) and Bd3 aim at the kingside. Knight d2-f3-e5, queen on c2/e2, rooks e1/f1 for e4.

Plan: Complete the setup, castle, then Ne5, Qf3 or e4. Against ...Qb6, trade queens or defend b2 with Qb3/Qc1.

King: Castle kingside after Bd3; e3/f2 form a safe shell. **Opponent:** ...c5 + ...Qb6 hitting b2, ...Bf5 to trade bishops, or ...e5.

Watch out: Do not let ...c5 + ...Qb6 + ...Nh5 harass the bishop and b2 without a plan.

Expert and coach view

What a coach would tell you

Solid is not automatic: learn the plan against ...c5/...Qb6, ...Bf5 and the King's Indian setups. Know when to switch to an e4 or c4 break.

Why play it

Low-theory 1.d4 systems: a solid setup that you can reach against many Black replies.

Typical mistakes

- Playing the same setup without checking tactical issues (...Qb6, ...Nh5, ...Bf5).
- Ignoring the c5/d4 tension and allowing ...Qb6 attacks on b2.
- Trading pieces with no plan for your light-squared bishop.

Typical tactics and traps

- ...Qb6 hitting b2 after the bishop leaves the c1-h6 diagonal.
- ...Nh5 forks the bishop and f4/g3 squares when Bf4 is loose.

Endgame and middlegame outlook

Equal-ish middlegames; success depends on planning, not memory.

Study checklist

[ ] Play the main line on a board and say each move's purpose aloud.

[ ] Learn the five coach questions by heart; answer them without notes.

[ ] Drill two sub-variations until the moves feel automatic.

[ ] Play three games with the opening, then review where you left theory.

[ ] Re-read the traps page the day before a tournament.

The opening tree

Every named line in this family as a tree. Gray moves are inherited from the parent; green after the arrow are the new moves that define the variation. Large green dots mark branches with 10 or more lines.

- **London System (all lines)** A48
  `1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Bf4`
  - **Poisoned Pawn Variation** D02
    `1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 d5 3.Bf4 c5 4.e3 Qb6 5.Nc3`

One-page memory sheet

Move-order pattern

```
1.d4 Nf6 2.Nf3 g6 3.Bf4 Bg7 4.e3
```

Plan chain

White	d4 -> Bf4 -> e3 -> c3 -> Nf3
Black	d5 -> Nf6 -> e6 -> c5 -> Nc6

Three rules to remember

1. c3, d4, e3, Bf4 or Bg5, then Ne5 and a kingside plan.
2. Complete the setup, castle, then Ne5/Qf3 or e4; against ...c5/...Qb6 trade or defend b2.
3. White wants a safe fast setup and a kingside plan; Black wants ...c5/...Bf5 and an equal fight for the centre.

Pawn structure in one line

A compact pyramid (c3/d4/e3), fast development and flexible plans.